conference at the BJP headquarters after the Lok Sabha polls, he told journalists, ‘whenever any one of you wants to do any research, I will tell the party president that we should pass on this information to those interested journalists’. The point, Modi argued, was that ‘how you run such an organisation is a very big thing’ in a ‘democratic set-up’. ‘Mobilising such a big human resource and getting them to do such targeted activities is very hard and big work by itself,’ he explained. ‘Only after that you can fight an election as an organisation. This is democracy’s real strength by itself.’[84]

Between 2016 and 2019, the BJP created new Nanaji Deshmukh Libraries and e-libraries in six states: Raipur (Chhattisgarh),[85] Bhopal (Madhya Pradesh),[86] Jaipur (Rajasthan),[87] Bengaluru (Karnataka),[88] Ranchi (Jharkhand)[89] and Jammu (Union Territory of Jammu & Kashmir).[90] Each of these was personally inaugurated by Amit Shah, who specially flew down for the events.

Former civil servant Dr Aseervatham Achary played a key role in creating the libraries as the BJP’s coordinator for its documentation and library department. He told me that both Amit Shah and his successor as party president, J.P. Nadda, saw these libraries as ‘high priority’. ‘They took personal interest in monitoring progress of these projects at every level and ensured they are inaugurated well within the timeframe,’ he said. ‘No other party has even thought of hosting a vast repository of knowledge resources in the digital format.’ The rare manuscripts and archival party documents online that his team hosts, he pointed out, were ‘managed scientifically’ and by ‘employing tools as prescribed by library science’. I asked him who the target audience was. His answer: party karyakartas, research scholars, students, intellectuals, party spokespersons, journalists from print and electronic media. ‘It aims to become a reference library for intellectuals,’ he concluded.[91]

When I asked Vinay Sahasrabuddhe how different the BJP’s expansion under Amit Shah’s presidency was compared to that of his predecessors, he counted the work of building party offices and the focus on archives as the two primary differentiators. ‘Number one is the level of activism with which he has worked on the party or organisation,’ he said. ‘I don’t think any of his predecessors can